

Multiple Forms of Energy in Electromagnetism

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Energy in Electromagnetism

All the equations we will discuss in this note:

$$\left\{ \begin{array}{l} W = \frac{\epsilon_0}{2} \int_{\mathbb{R}^3} E^2 d\tau \\ W = \frac{1}{2} CV^2 \end{array} \right. \quad \left\{ \begin{array}{l} W = \frac{1}{2\mu_0} \int_{\mathbb{R}^3} B^2 d\tau \\ W = \frac{1}{2} LI^2 \end{array} \right. \quad \left\{ \begin{array}{l} W = \frac{1}{2} \int \mathbf{D} \cdot \mathbf{E} d\tau \\ U_{\text{dip}} = -\mathbf{p} \cdot \mathbf{E} \\ U_{\text{dip}} = -\mathbf{m} \cdot \mathbf{B} \end{array} \right.$$

1 The Energy in Electric Fields

1.1 Electric Field

The force acting on a charge q in the electric field $\mathbf{E}$ is $q\mathbf{E}$. If we want to "Bring" to the position $\mathbf{r}$ from infinity, we need to always apply the opposite force $-q\mathbf{E}$ to resist the electric force. So, the total work (energy) we do is

$$W = \int \mathbf{F}_{\text{us}} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell} = -q \int_{\infty}^{\mathbf{r}} \mathbf{E} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell} = -q \int_{\infty}^{\mathbf{r}} (-\nabla V) \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell} = qV(\mathbf{r}), \quad (1)$$

where we set $V(\infty) = 0$. Therefore, the work done by us is denoted by:

$$W = qV(\mathbf{r}). \quad (2)$$

As a result, we apply force on the charge and give it energy, then the energy is transferred to the potential energy of the electric field. Now, we want to build a configuration that contains many charges, so we must do works on the charges and transfer the works to be stored in the field.

Suppose we bring the charge q_i from infinity to the position $\mathbf{r}_i$. If there exists charge(s) q_j , then we need to do work on q_i , that is:

$$W = q_i V(\mathbf{r}_i), \quad (3)$$

where V is the potential¹ due to q_j , so we obtain

$$W = q_i \left(\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{q_j}{r_{ij}} \right). \quad (4)$$

The total energy we apply (stored in the field) is the summation all the energy in terms of (4), for every j , every i :

$$W_{\text{tot}} = \underbrace{\sum_i \sum_{j>i} q_i \left(\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{q_j}{r_{ij}} \right)}_{\text{To avoid double counting, we must multiply 1/2 or restrict } j > i} = \frac{1}{2} \sum_i \sum_{j \neq i} q_i \left(\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{q_j}{r_{ij}} \right). \quad (5)$$

You can look up the slide of the first meeting in Classical Mechanics in the last semester to understand this $\frac{1}{2}$. In general,

$$W = \frac{1}{2} \sum_i q_i \left(\sum_{j \neq i} \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{q_j}{r_{ij}} \right) = \frac{1}{2} \sum_i q_i V(\mathbf{r}_i). \quad (6)$$

When the charges distribute continuously with charge density ρ , we can rewrite (6) in the form:

$$W = \frac{1}{2} \int_{\mathcal{V}} \rho V d\tau = \frac{1}{2} \int_{\mathcal{V}} (\epsilon_0 \nabla \cdot \mathbf{E}) V d\tau = \frac{\epsilon_0}{2} \int_{\mathcal{V}} (\nabla \cdot \mathbf{E}) V d\tau. \quad (7)$$

By the Products Rules (iv), (7) can be written as

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\epsilon_0}{2} \int_{\mathcal{V}} (\nabla \cdot \mathbf{E}) V d\tau &= \frac{\epsilon_0}{2} \left[\int_{\mathcal{V}} \nabla \cdot (V \mathbf{E}) d\tau - \int_{\mathcal{V}} \mathbf{E} \cdot \underbrace{(\nabla V)}_{=-\mathbf{E}} d\tau \right] \\ &= \frac{\epsilon_0}{2} \oint_{\mathcal{V}} V \mathbf{E} \cdot d\mathbf{a} + \frac{\epsilon_0}{2} \int_{\mathcal{V}} E^2 d\tau. \end{aligned}$$

Note that the dimensions of $V \sim 1/r$ and $E \sim 1/r^2$, while $da \sim r^2$, which means that $V \mathbf{E} \cdot d\mathbf{a} \sim 1/r$. So, when we take the bounded region $\mathcal{V}$ extremely large ($\mathcal{V} \rightarrow \text{all space}$), then the first surface integral will decrease really fast and finally vanish. Hence, the total energy stored in the field is:

$$\boxed{W = \frac{\epsilon_0}{2} \int_{\text{all space}} E^2 d\tau.} \quad (8)$$

We can further define the energy density u_e

$$u_e = \frac{\epsilon_0}{2} E^2. \quad (9)$$

¹The form of the potentials (whether electric or magnetic) is mentioned in *Potential and Vector Potential with Multipole Expansion*, Yen-Ting Wu

1.2 Capacitance

The capacitance C is defined as

$$C := \frac{Q}{V}, \quad (10)$$

where V is, by definition, the potential of the positive conductor minus that of the negative one. Similarly, the charge Q is on the **positive** conductor (See the appendix of *Polarization & Magnetization, Yen-Ting Wu*). So, the value of the capacitor is always greater than zero, and it represents the ability to store charges in a potential difference V . By (2), the energy stored in the capacitor is (you need to do work to transport the next piece of charge):

$$dW = dq \cdot V = dq \left(\frac{q}{C} \right), \quad (11)$$

and integrate the both sides from $q = 0$ to $q = Q$ in a continuous process:

$$\int dW = W = \int_0^Q \frac{q}{C} dq = \frac{1}{2} \frac{Q^2}{C}.$$

Since $Q = CV$ by the definition, we have

$$\boxed{W = \frac{1}{2} CV^2.} \quad (12)$$

This indicates that to charge up a capacitor, we need to "Provide" W to the capacitor with a specific capacitance, and the energy we give will be stored in the capacitor.

2 The Energy in Magnetic Fields

2.1 Inductance

There are two loops with the constant current, as shown below:

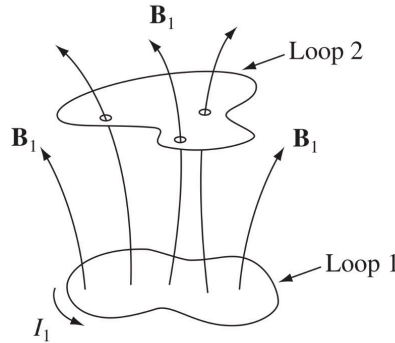


Figure 1: Two loops configuration with the magnetic flux

By Biot-Savart's law, the magnetic field $\mathbf{B}$ of the closed loop is given by

$$\mathbf{B}_1 = \frac{\mu_0 I_1}{4\pi} \oint \frac{d\boldsymbol{\ell}_1 \times \hat{\mathbf{r}}}{r^2}. \quad (13)$$

In addition, the flux through loop 2 is

$$\Phi_2 = \int \mathbf{B}_1 \cdot d\mathbf{a}_2, \quad (14)$$

and substitute the vector potential $\mathbf{B} = \nabla \times \mathbf{A}_1$ into (14), we have:

$$\Phi_2 = \int (\nabla \times \mathbf{A}_1) \cdot d\mathbf{a}_2 = \oint \mathbf{A}_1 \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell}_2. \quad (15)$$

The vector potential $\mathbf{A}_1$ is given by the solution to the poisson equation:

$$\mathbf{A}_1 = \frac{\mu_0 I_1}{4\pi} \oint \frac{d\boldsymbol{\ell}_1}{r},$$

and therefore the flux Φ_2 becomes

$$\Phi_2 = \oint \mathbf{A}_1 \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell}_2 = \left[\frac{\mu_0}{4\pi} \oint \left(\oint \frac{d\boldsymbol{\ell}_1}{r} \right) \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell}_2 \right] I_1 = \left(\frac{\mu_0}{4\pi} \oint \oint \frac{d\boldsymbol{\ell}_1}{r} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell}_2 \right) I_1. \quad (16)$$

It implies that the flux is proportional to the amplitude of the current, no matter what shape the loop takes. So we can say that

$$\Phi = \alpha I, \quad (17)$$

where α is the proportionality. In this case, $\Phi_2 = \alpha_{21} I_1$, where

$$\alpha_{21} = \frac{\mu_0}{4\pi} \oint \oint \frac{d\boldsymbol{\ell}_1}{r} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell}_2 = \frac{\mu_0}{4\pi} \oint \oint \frac{d\boldsymbol{\ell}_2}{r} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell}_1 = \alpha_{12}. \quad (18)$$

In conclusion, under the same configuration, or with the specific current and magnetic field, the proportionalities are the same. This leads to the $\text{emf}(\mathcal{E})$ when one of the currents varies in time with the same constant. By flux law,

$$\mathcal{E}_2 = -\frac{d\Phi_2}{dt} = -\alpha \frac{dI_1}{dt}. \quad (19)$$

It also means that the changing current dI_1 will induce the current (or emf) of loop 2. However, the loop can also induce an emf by itself; the flux through its own loop is also proportional to its current. Here, we define the proportionality as L , which is called **Inductance**, it satisfies

$$\Phi = LI. \quad (20)$$

When the current changes, the emf induced in the loop itself is:

$$\mathcal{E} = -\frac{d\Phi}{dt} = -L\frac{dI}{dt}. \quad (21)$$

Now, we can finally start to discuss the energy of the inductance and the energy stored in the magnetic field. The work dW done by us in an infinitesimal time on the charge through the loop is:

$$dW = \underbrace{-\oint d\mathbf{F} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell}}_{\substack{\text{Minus sign means that the} \\ \text{work done by us is} \\ \text{against the emf}}} = -dq \oint \mathbf{E} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell}$$

$$\Rightarrow \frac{dW}{dt} = -\underbrace{I}_{dq/dt} \oint \mathbf{E} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell} = -\mathcal{E}I,$$

so the work done per unit time is:

$$\frac{dW}{dt} = LI\frac{dI}{dt} \Leftrightarrow dW = LI dI. \quad (22)$$

During the process of doing work, the current gradually increases. As a result, the resistance we must overcome becomes larger, and therefore, more energy is required. We start with $I = 0$ and build it up to I , then the total work done by us W_{us} , which is also stored in the field is:

$$W_{\text{us}} = \int_0^I LI' dI' = \frac{1}{2}LI^2. \quad (23)$$

2.2 Magnetic Field

We've known that the flux through the loop itself is

$$\Phi = \int \underbrace{\mathbf{B}}_{\substack{\text{Caused by loop}}} \cdot d\mathbf{a} = \oint \mathbf{A} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell} = LI$$

Combining this with (23), we have

$$W = \frac{1}{2}I \oint \mathbf{A} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell} = \frac{1}{2} \oint \mathbf{A} \cdot \mathbf{I} d\boldsymbol{\ell}. \quad (24)$$

In general,

$$W = \frac{1}{2} \int_V \mathbf{A} \cdot \mathbf{J} d\tau = \frac{1}{2} \int_V \underbrace{\mathbf{A} \cdot \left(\frac{1}{\mu_0} \nabla \times \mathbf{B} \right)}_{\substack{\text{Faraday's Law without changing } \mathbf{E}}} d\tau = \frac{1}{2\mu_0} \int_V \mathbf{A} \cdot (\nabla \times \mathbf{B}) d\tau. \quad (25)$$

Apply the Products Rules (iii), (25) can be written as

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{1}{2\mu_0} \int_{\mathcal{V}} \mathbf{A} \cdot (\nabla \times \mathbf{B}) d\tau &= \frac{1}{2\mu_0} \left[\int_{\mathcal{V}} \mathbf{B} \cdot \underbrace{(\nabla \times \mathbf{A})}_{=\mathbf{B}} d\tau - \int_{\mathcal{V}} \nabla \cdot (\mathbf{A} \times \mathbf{B}) d\tau \right] \\ &= \frac{1}{2\mu_0} \left[\int_{\mathcal{V}} B^2 d\tau - \oint_{\partial\mathcal{V}} (\mathbf{A} \times \mathbf{B}) \cdot d\mathbf{a} \right].\end{aligned}$$

Likewise, we note that the dimensions of $A \sim 1/r$ and $B \sim 1/r^2$, while $da \sim r^2$, which means that $(\mathbf{A} \times \mathbf{B}) \cdot d\mathbf{a} \sim 1/r$. So, when we take the bounded region $\mathcal{V}$ extremely large ($\mathcal{V} \rightarrow \text{all space}$), then the second surface integral will decrease really fast and finally vanish. Hence, the total energy stored in the field is:

$$\boxed{W = \frac{1}{2\mu_0} \int_{\text{all space}} B^2 d\tau.} \quad (26)$$

We can further define the energy density u_m in the magnetic field:

$$u_m = \frac{1}{2\mu_0} B^2 \quad (27)$$

3 The Energy of a Dipole and a Linear Dielectric in Ideal Dipole Systems

3.1 Electric Dipole

The charge $-q$ is located at position $\mathbf{r}$ relative to the origin, while the charge $+q$ is located at $\mathbf{r}'$. The vector $\mathbf{d}$ denotes the displacement from $-q$ to $+q$, such that $\mathbf{r}' = \mathbf{r} + \mathbf{d}$. As shown below

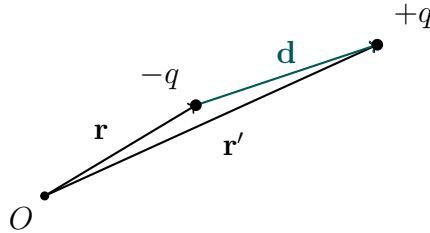


Figure 2: Geometry of an electric dipole.

So, the total energy stored in this system is:

$$\begin{aligned}
U &= qV(\mathbf{r} + \mathbf{d}) + \left[-qV(\mathbf{r}) \right] \\
&= q \left[V(\mathbf{r} + \mathbf{d}) - V(\mathbf{r}) \right] \\
&= q \left[- \int_{\mathbf{r}}^{\mathbf{r}+\mathbf{d}} \mathbf{E} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell} \right] = q(-\mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{d}) = -\mathbf{E} \cdot q\mathbf{d},
\end{aligned}$$

for an ideal dipole. Remember that $\mathbf{p} = q\mathbf{d}$ So, the energy U can be written as:

$$\boxed{U = -\mathbf{p} \cdot \mathbf{E}.} \quad (28)$$

3.2 Magnetic Dipole

Consider a small current loop carrying steady current I . The magnetic force acting on a line element $d\boldsymbol{\ell}$ is

$$d\mathbf{F} = I d\boldsymbol{\ell} \times \mathbf{B}(\mathbf{r}).$$

Hence the total force on the loop is

$$\mathbf{F} = I \oint d\boldsymbol{\ell} \times \mathbf{B}(\mathbf{r}). \quad (29)$$

To extract the dipole approximation, choose a reference point $\mathbf{r}_0$ inside the loop and write

$$\mathbf{r} = \mathbf{r}_0 + \boldsymbol{\alpha},$$

where $\boldsymbol{\alpha}$ denotes the displacement from the reference point to the current element. Since the loop is assumed to be small, expand the magnetic field around $\mathbf{r}_0$:

$$\mathbf{B}(\mathbf{r}) = \mathbf{B}(\mathbf{r}_0) + (\boldsymbol{\alpha} \cdot \boldsymbol{\nabla})\mathbf{B}(\mathbf{r}_0) + \cdots. \quad (30)$$

Substituting this into the force integral gives

$$\mathbf{F} = I \oint d\boldsymbol{\ell} \times [\mathbf{B}(\mathbf{r}_0) + (\boldsymbol{\alpha} \cdot \boldsymbol{\nabla})\mathbf{B}(\mathbf{r}_0)].$$

The first term vanishes because $\mathbf{B}(\mathbf{r}_0)$ is constant over the loop:

$$I \oint d\boldsymbol{\ell} \times \mathbf{B}(\mathbf{r}_0) = I \left(\oint d\boldsymbol{\ell} \right) \times \mathbf{B}(\mathbf{r}_0) = 0.$$

Therefore, to first order,

$$\mathbf{F} = I \oint d\boldsymbol{\ell} \times [(\boldsymbol{\alpha} \cdot \boldsymbol{\nabla})\mathbf{B}].$$

Now write this in index notation:

$$F_i = I \oint \epsilon_{ijk} d\ell_j \alpha_l \partial_l B_k. \quad (31)$$

Since $\partial_l B_k$ is evaluated at $\mathbf{r}_0$, it is independent of the integration variable and can be taken outside the integral:

$$F_i = I \epsilon_{ijk} \partial_l B_k \oint \alpha_l d\ell_j.$$

Next, only the antisymmetric part of $\alpha_l d\ell_j$ contributes, because it is contracted with ϵ_{ijk} . Thus,

$$\oint \alpha_l d\ell_j \longrightarrow \frac{1}{2} \oint (\alpha_l d\ell_j - \alpha_j d\ell_l).$$

Hence,

$$F_i = \frac{I}{2} \epsilon_{ijk} \partial_l B_k \oint (\alpha_l d\ell_j - \alpha_j d\ell_l).$$

Now introduce the area vector of the loop:

$$a_m = \frac{1}{2} \oint (\boldsymbol{\alpha} \times d\boldsymbol{\ell})_m = \frac{1}{2} \epsilon_{mjl} \oint \alpha_j d\ell_l.$$

Equivalently,

$$\oint (\alpha_l d\ell_j - \alpha_j d\ell_l) = 2 \epsilon_{ljm} a_m.$$

Substituting this into the force expression,

$$F_i = \frac{I}{2} \epsilon_{ijk} \partial_l B_k (2 \epsilon_{ljm} a_m),$$

so that

$$\begin{aligned} F_i &= I \epsilon_{ijk} \epsilon_{ljm} \partial_l B_k a_m \\ &= I (\delta_{il} \delta_{km} - \delta_{im} \delta_{kl}) \partial_l B_k a_m \\ &= I a_m \partial_i B_m - I a_i \partial_k B_k. \end{aligned}$$

By Maxwell's equation

$$\boldsymbol{\nabla} \cdot \mathbf{B} = 0,$$

the second term vanishes, and therefore

$$F_i = I a_m \partial_i B_m. \quad (32)$$

Finally, define the magnetic dipole moment

$$\mathbf{m} = I \mathbf{a}, \quad m_m = I a_m.$$

Then

$$F_i = m_m \partial_i B_m. \quad (33)$$

Since $\mathbf{m}$ is treated as constant with respect to spatial differentiation,

$$\partial_i(\mathbf{m} \cdot \mathbf{B}) = \partial_i(m_m B_m) = m_m \partial_i B_m.$$

Hence we conclude

$$\mathbf{F} = \nabla(\mathbf{m} \cdot \mathbf{B}). \quad (34)$$

So, the energy stored in the magnetic dipole field is:

$$U = - \int_{\infty}^{\mathbf{r}} \mathbf{F} \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell} = - \int_{\infty}^{\mathbf{r}} \nabla(\mathbf{m} \cdot \mathbf{B}) \cdot d\boldsymbol{\ell}, \quad (35)$$

where the magnetic field at $\mathbf{r} = \infty$ is zero, so:

$$\boxed{U = -\mathbf{m} \cdot \mathbf{B}.} \quad (36)$$

3.3 Linear Medium

By (7), we can obtain the infinitesimal difference of the energy dW in a linear medium:

$$dW = \int (d\varrho_f) V d\tau = \int \nabla \cdot (d\mathbf{D}) V d\tau.$$

This can be denoted by the index notation:

$$\begin{aligned} dW &= \int V \partial_i (dD)_i d\tau \quad V \partial_i (dD)_i = \partial_i (V dD_i) - (\partial_i V) (dD)_i \\ &= \int \partial_i (V dD_i) d\tau - \int \underbrace{(\partial_i V)}_{=-E_i} (dD)_i d\tau \\ &= \oint V dD_i d\tau + \int E_i (dD)_i d\tau. \end{aligned}$$

The boundary term will vanish because of the dimensions (recall the discussion in the energy of the electric & magnetic fields). Because its a linear dielectric, the term $(dD)_i = (d\epsilon E)_i = \epsilon (dE)_i$. Therefore, we have

$$E_i dD_i = \epsilon (E_i dE_i) = \frac{1}{2} \epsilon d(E_i E_i) = d \left(\frac{1}{2} E_i D_i \right). \quad (37)$$

Substituting (37) into dW , we can obtain

$$dW = \int d \left(\frac{1}{2} E_i D_i \right) d\tau \Rightarrow W = \frac{1}{2} \int E_i D_i d\tau, \quad (38)$$

as a result, the energy can be written as

$$\boxed{W = \frac{1}{2} \int \mathbf{D} \cdot \mathbf{E} d\tau.} \quad (39)$$

Some Identities

Triple Products:

$$\begin{cases} \mathbf{A} \cdot (\mathbf{B} \times \mathbf{C}) = \mathbf{B} \cdot (\mathbf{C} \times \mathbf{A}) = \mathbf{C} \cdot (\mathbf{A} \times \mathbf{B}) \\ \mathbf{A} \times (\mathbf{B} \times \mathbf{C}) = \mathbf{B}(\mathbf{A} \cdot \mathbf{C}) - \mathbf{C}(\mathbf{A} \cdot \mathbf{B}) \quad \text{Bac(k)-Cab law} \end{cases}$$

Products Rules:

$$\begin{cases} \nabla(fg) = f(\nabla g) + g(\nabla f) \\ \nabla(\mathbf{A} \cdot \mathbf{B}) = \mathbf{A} \times (\nabla \times \mathbf{B}) + \mathbf{B}(\nabla \times \mathbf{A}) + (\mathbf{A} \cdot \nabla)\mathbf{B} + (\mathbf{B} \cdot \nabla)\mathbf{A} \\ \nabla \cdot (\mathbf{A} \times \mathbf{B}) = \mathbf{B} \cdot (\nabla \times \mathbf{A}) - \mathbf{A} \cdot (\nabla \times \mathbf{B}) \\ \nabla \cdot (f\mathbf{A}) = f(\nabla \cdot \mathbf{A}) + \mathbf{A} \cdot \nabla f \\ \nabla \times (f\mathbf{A}) = f(\nabla \times \mathbf{A}) - \mathbf{A} \times \nabla f \\ \nabla \times (\mathbf{A} \times \mathbf{B}) = (\mathbf{B} \cdot \nabla)\mathbf{A} - (\mathbf{A} \cdot \nabla)\mathbf{B} + \mathbf{A}(\nabla \cdot \mathbf{B}) - \mathbf{B}(\nabla \cdot \mathbf{A}) \end{cases}$$

Second Derivatives:

$$\begin{cases} \nabla \cdot (\nabla \times \mathbf{A}) = 0 \\ \nabla \times (\nabla f) = \mathbf{0} \\ \nabla \times (\nabla \times \mathbf{A}) = \nabla(\nabla \cdot \mathbf{A}) - \nabla^2 \mathbf{A} \end{cases}$$

Green's Identities and Some Integrals:

$$\left\{ \begin{array}{l} \int_{\mathcal{V}} (T \nabla^2 U - U \nabla^2 T) d\tau = \oint_S (T \nabla U - U \nabla T) \cdot d\mathbf{a} \\ \int_S \nabla T \times d\mathbf{a} = - \oint_{\mathcal{P}} T d\boldsymbol{\ell} \\ \oint (\mathbf{c} \cdot \mathbf{r}) d\boldsymbol{\ell} = \left(\int d\mathbf{a} \right) \times \mathbf{c} \\ \int_{\mathcal{V}} \nabla \times \mathbf{F} d\tau = - \oint_S \mathbf{F} \times d\mathbf{a} \end{array} \right.$$

Delta functions:

$$\left\{ \begin{array}{l} \nabla \cdot \left(\frac{\hat{\boldsymbol{\mathcal{R}}}}{\mathcal{R}^2} \right) = 4\pi\delta^3(\boldsymbol{\mathcal{R}}) \\ \nabla \left(\frac{1}{\mathcal{R}} \right) = \nabla \left(\frac{1}{\underbrace{\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}'}_{\boldsymbol{\mathcal{R}}}} \right) = -\frac{\hat{\boldsymbol{\mathcal{R}}}}{\mathcal{R}^2} \\ \nabla' \left(\frac{1}{\mathcal{R}} \right) = \nabla' \left(\frac{1}{\underbrace{\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}'}_{\boldsymbol{\mathcal{R}}}} \right) = \frac{\hat{\boldsymbol{\mathcal{R}}}}{\mathcal{R}^2} \\ \nabla^2 \left(\frac{1}{\mathcal{R}} \right) = -4\pi\delta^3(\boldsymbol{\mathcal{R}}) \end{array} \right.$$